



“... systematic **low wages** ... force women to **sell sex** to **survive**. ”

ANDREA DWORKIN,
FEMINIST, 1983

THROUGHOUT HISTORY, women and girls have often entered into prostitution out of economic desperation or force, and continue to do so today. However in many societies, prostitution was linked to religion too. Sacred prostitution and sacred sex (in which money is not involved) are practices that date back to the ancient world. In ancient Greece and Rome, sacred prostitution and sex was practiced at temples dedicated to Aphrodite and Venus. There is evidence that prostitution was regulated in ancient Rome and that the state may have owned large brothels in the 4th century BCE. In Aztec society, women (and some men), were allowed to work as prostitutes at the *Cihuacalli*, or “House of

◀ English “man trap”

This engraving of an English prostitute c. 1780 was published in German Marxist scholar Eduard Fuchs’s *Sittengeschichte* (1911-1912), art and caricatures on the theme of morality.

THROUGH THE AGES

Prostitution

Women and girls—and boys and men of lesser social status—have been providing sex for money since ancient times. Governments have long faced the challenge of how to legislate the practice, choosing variously to ban it outright or to attempt to regulate it.